nations – whose populations range from 740,000 (Solomon Islands) to 11,000 (Tuvalu) – had substantial leeway to decide which way to tack and were able to extract considerable concessions and aid.[2]

Other small states, such as Qatar, have established themselves as important players in the geopolitical arena. With only 300,000 citizens, Qatar is nevertheless pursuing ambitious foreign policy aims in the Middle East, is playing an outsized role in the global economy and is home to Al Jazeera, the Arab world's most influential TV network. One might argue that Qatar is able to punch well above its weight because it is the third-largest exporter of natural gas in the world. Yet in a different international setting, that would have made Qatar not an independent actor but the first course on the menu of any imperial conqueror. It is telling that, as of 2024, Qatar's much bigger neighbours and the world's hegemonic powers are letting the tiny Gulf state hold on to its fabulous riches. Many people describe the international system as a jungle. If so, it is a jungle in which tigers allow fat chickens to live in relative safety.

Qatar, Tonga, Tuvalu, Kiribati and the Solomon Islands all indicate that we are living in a post-imperial era. They gained their independence from the British Empire in the 1970s, as part of the final demise of the European imperial order. The leverage they now have in the international arena testifies that in the first quarter of the twenty-first century power is distributed between a relatively large number of players, rather than monopolised by a few empires.

How might the rise of the new computer network change the shape of international politics? Aside from apocalyptic scenarios such as a dictatorial AI launching a nuclear war, or a terrorist AI instigating a lethal pandemic, computers pose two main challenges to the current international system. First, since computers make it easier to concentrate information and power in a central hub, humanity could enter a new imperial era. A few empires (or perhaps a single empire) might bring the whole world under a much tighter grip than that of the British Empire or the Soviet Empire. Tonga, Tuvalu and Qatar would be transformed from independent states into colonial possessions – just as they were fifty years ago.

Second, humanity could split along a new Silicon Curtain that would pass between rival digital empires. As each regime chooses its own answer to the AI alignment problem, to the dictator's dilemma and to other technological quandaries, each might create a separate and very different